Sampoorna Kranti

The nationwide campaign for democratic rights that Jayaprakash Narayan led in 1974–77 seems in retrospect a natural corollary of his brilliant role in the 1942 Quit India movement and the disquiet he expressed when Mahatma Gandhi was assassinated in 1948. The Emergency Indira Gandhi was panicked into declaring was central to the 1970s' story, but JP's goal of 'total revolution' went far beyond defeating a political foe. That modern free India must aim simultaneously at individual liberty and equal rights for all Indians is the takeaway from the JP movement. Having drawn Indians of every stripe into a struggle for democratic rights, that movement remains, in 2022, a hope-giving memory.





KM KISHAN

Mandal Agitation

If history endowed power to India's high castes, and constitutionally-mandated reservations brought some relief to SC/ STs, that still left half the population uncared-for. It was Dr Ram Manohar Lohia who in the 1950s started a movement for the rights of the nation's neglected middle castes—the OBCs. And it was V.P. Singh who, by implementing in 1990 recommendations of the Mandal Commission, revealed the OBC's salience. After first fiercely opposing OBC quotas in colleges and government jobs, the Hindu right backed the new quotas in a bid to deploy OBCs for a divisive, anti-Muslim push.